



Constipation in Pregnancy

Safe relief strategies during pregnancy

When does constipation generally start during pregnancy?

Constipation tends to start as early as progesterone levels rise, around the second to third month of pregnancy. It may get worse as pregnancy progresses and your uterus grows.

What causes constipation during pregnancy?

As with many other pregnancy symptoms, pregnancy hormones are the culprit behind constipation. Progesterone causes the muscles in your

bowels to relax, allowing food to hang around longer in the digestive tract. The upside is there's added time for nutrients to be absorbed into

your bloodstream and reach your baby. The downside is you end up with a waste-product traffic jam. Your expanding uterus also takes up

valuable space normally occupied by your bowel, cramping its usual activity.

What can I do about constipation when I'm pregnant?

You don't have to resign yourself to nine months of discomfort. There are plenty of tactics to combat colon congestion (all the while heading

off hemorrhoids, a common side effect of constipation):

- Fight back with fiber. Fiber-rich foods help you eliminate waste; aim for 25 to 35 grams each day. Check the food labels if you want, but there's no need to do the math. Instead, focus on simply eating plenty of whole grain cereals and breads, legumes (edamame and chickpeas), fresh fruits and veggies (raw or lightly cooked — preferably with skin left on), and dried fruits. Going for the green can also help you go, in both the form of leafy green vegetables and kiwi fruit, which packs a potent laxative effect. Sample from this fiber-rich and tasty menu to get started. Really plugged up? Try adding some bran or psyllium to your diet, starting with a sprinkle and increasing as needed. Be sure to check with your doctor first before you do this, though, and don't go overboard, since these fiber powerhouses can carry away important nutrients before they can be absorbed. (Also be prepared for some flatulence, another common complaint of pregnancy as well as a temporary side effect of upping the fiber in your diet.)
- Resist refined. Try to avoid refined grains (white bread, white rice, refined cereals and pasta) when you can; they tend to back things up.
- Drink up. Downing between eight and 10 8-ounce glasses of fluids (water, vegetable or fruit juice and broth) every day keeps solids moving through your digestive tract and makes your stool soft and easier to pass. You can also turn to warm liquids, including that health spa staple, hot water and lemon, to help stimulate peristalsis (the intestinal contractions that help you go). Prune juice is a good pick for truly tough cases, since it's a mild laxative.
- Don't max out at mealtime. Big meals can overtax your digestive tract, leading to things getting backed up. Try eating six mini-meals a day rather than three large ones and you might also experience less gas and bloating.
- Go when you gotta go. Regularly holding it in can weaken the muscles that control your bowels and lead to constipation, so try to go whenever